

THE HOMESTEAD ACT ►

In 1862, the US government passed a law that encouraged new settlers to move westward by offering them land for free if they agreed to live and farm on it for at least five years. This was another blow to Indigenous nations, whose stolen lands were traded in this way. More than 250,000 sq miles (650,000 sq km), or nearly 10 percent of the total area of the US, was given to homesteaders under this law.



▼ TRANSCONTINENTAL RAILROAD

After years of construction, in 1869, two cross-country railroads—the eastern Union Pacific Railroad and the western Central Pacific Railroad—were finally linked at Promontory Point in Utah (below). The coasts of America were now joined together by rail. This event was symbolic of the permanent settlement of the US across North America.



▲ THE CHANGING FRONTIER

After the Thirteen Colonies won independence from Britain in 1783, the US rapidly gained new territory from France, Spain, Britain, and Mexico, and added the independent republic of Texas. In 1867, it bought Alaska from Russia for \$7.2 million, before taking over the former Kingdom of Hawaii in 1898.



INDIGENOUS RESISTANCE ▼

Throughout this period of expansion, settlers faced fierce resistance from the Indigenous peoples, who fought for their lands and their livelihoods. An Apache war leader and healer, Geronimo (below), held out against US invasions for decades, but his capture in 1886 weakened the resistance considerably.

